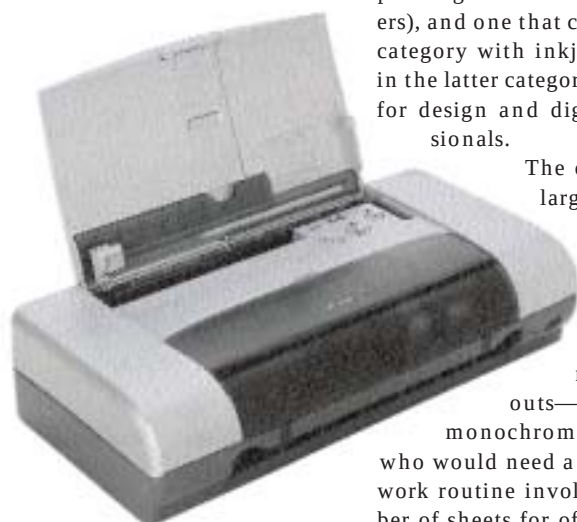




PC penetration in homes and small offices has increased to such an extent that the need for peripherals such as printers has skyrocketed. Whether you seek a decent home printer, or a professional printing solution, the market offers a variety of options, depending on your need and budget. The printer market is divided into two major chunks, one that offers reliable bulk printing solutions (in the form of laser printers), and one that caters to the home printing category with inkjet printers. Also included in the latter category are high-end inkjets that for design and digital photography professionals.

The choice of printer depends largely on usage, than on quality of printing or performance parameters. Laser printers have traditionally been expensive, but they offer good economic and crisp print-outs—at least as far as bulk monochrome printing is concerned. So who would need a laser printer? If your daily work routine involves printing a large number of sheets for office use and, more importantly, you need the print-outs fast, you need a laser printer. If you're not satisfied with your old inkjet printer and are thinking of upgrading to something better and faster, and something that still fits your budget, you need to look at a laser printer.

Printing in offices and SoHo segments mostly involve bulk text print-outs and hence laser printers are the most viable options. Also, as these printers come with a network option—they can be used over a network as a shared resource, making them ideal for an office environment. Another important feature one should look for is the amount of buffer memory—the more the better, especially if the printer is on a network. Having a large paper capacity is also an added advantage for professional laser printers, for a fill-and-forget mode of operation.

Inkjet printers provide good colour print-outs at a reasonable price, hence they are more

or less suitable for the home segment, where the work load is occasional, and restricted to a few pages. High-end inkjet printers provide excellent digital imaging for professionals who require quality print-outs. In an inkjet printer, one should be looking at features such as USB interface, which increases printing speed drastically over the older parallel interface. High-end inkjet printers today have the facility to print from a digital camera directly. Some vendors also have specialised printers for the same job.

If you need a printer for the typical office environment, one that is going to be used as a shared resource, a laser printer is the best bet. But if you are looking for a home printer, to carry out small jobs, an inkjet printer will suffice. If you need a printer for a small office where you will be using it for just a few print-outs a day, opt for a mid-range inkjet printer that can do the job without burning a hole in your pocket.

Market Overview

Gone are the days when people would shy away from a inkjet printer, or a laser printer simply because of the cost involved, and settle for an ageing dot matrix printer. Due to the fierce competition between the major players in the printer market, costs have drastically fallen, making them more affordable. This cut-throat competition among the vendors has benefited end-users in more than one way. Where an entry level inkjet printer used to cost around Rs 6,000 to Rs 7,000, a year ago, today the same printer costs around Rs 3,000 to 4,000. Similarly, an entry level laser printer that cost Rs 20,000 earlier, costs around Rs 13,000—a huge reduction when you look at the price to performance ratio.

The laser printer market, was previously ruled by two major brands—HP and Canon. But now companies such as Samsung, Lexmark, Wipro and Epson have entered the fray and the resulting competition among them has seen prices take a nosedive. All of these companies have slew of models that one can opt for depending upon the budget and requirements. Wipro offers the cheapest solu-



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